Sheila Birling

At the start of the play she is '*very pleased with life*'. She is young, attractive and has just become engaged. ***Presented as a spoilt, materialistic and frivolous upper- class girl .*** Sheila is portrayed as naïve, shallow , self – centred, materialistic and superficial in the beginning, but undergoes a tremendous amount of learning and growth during the play. Represents hope and change from exploitative capitalism to shared responsibility and community consciousness. She displays a genuine sense of remorse, sensitivity and sympathy for Eva Smith when she finds about her death, and her unreasonable behaviour which led to Eva losing her job her the store. She is very distressed by the girl's suicide and thinks that her father's behaviour was unacceptable. She readily agrees that she behaved very badly and insists that she never meant the girl any harm.

Her true nature is revealed when she is horrified by her part in the events and realises **' but these girls aren't cheap labour – they're people.'** She is also very perceptive; she realises the Gerald knew Daisy Renton, that Eric is guilty of mistreating Eva and that her father was unfair to Eva. She displays curiosity and a growing maturity as she becomes resentful of her parent's thinking and conduct. When she says '**I must obviously be a selfish, vindictive creature**,' we realise that by the end Priestley has successfully enabled Sheila to develop her social conscience and awareness of her own responsibilities and her errors in judgement. Sheila is the first to see the truth and learns from the Inspector's visit. Her response to the tragedy is one of the few encouraging things to come out of the play. She is genuinely upset when she hears of Eva's death and learns from her own behaviour. She also appears keen and anxious to change her behaviour in the future, '***I'll never, never do it again.***' She learns of her responsibilities to others less fortunate than herself (the idea of the community) and is sensitive. Her readiness to learn from experience is in great contrast to her parents.

Key Quotes

"I went to the manager and told him this girl had been very impertinent – and – and - "
"Why- you fool- he knows. Of course he knows. And I hate to think how much he knows that we don't know yet. You'll see. You'll see."
"You mustn't try to build up a kind of wall between us and that girl. If you do the Inspector will just break it down. And it'll be all the worse when he does"
Yes, go on, Mummy"
"(*rather distressed*) I can't help thinking about this girl- destroying herself so horribly- and I've been so happy tonight. Oh I wish you hadn't told me."
"But these girls aren't cheap labour- they're *people*."
"She was a very pretty girl…that didn't make it any better."
"And if I could help her now, I would-"
"I'll never, never do it again to anybody…I feel now I can never go there again"
"No, he's giving us the rope- so that we'll hang ourselves"
Bitterly "I suppose we're all nice people now

"It frightens me the way you talk"
"We killed her"

Themes

Power, Gender Inequality

Generation Gap

Social class

Social / Collective Responsibility

Explore how Priestley presents Sheila and ideas about change in the play?